

TRIFLES

First performed by the Provincetown Players at the Wharf Theatre, Provincetown, Mass., August 8, 1916.

GEORGE HENDERSON (County Attorney)

HENRY PETERS (Sheriff)

LEWIS HALE, A neighboring farmer

MRS PETERS

MRS HALE

SCENE

The kitchen is the now abandoned farmhouse of JOHN WRIGHT, _a gloomy kitchen, and left without having been put in order--unwashed pans under the sink, a loaf of bread outside the bread-box, a dish-towel on the table--other signs of incompleting work. At the rear the outer door opens and the_ SHERIFF _comes in followed by the_ COUNTY ATTORNEY _and_ HALE. _The_ SHERIFF _and_ HALE _are men in middle life, the_ COUNTY ATTORNEY _is a young man; all are much bundled up and go at once to the stove. They are followed by the two women--the_ SHERIFF_'s wife first; she is a slight wiry woman, a thin nervous face_. MRS HALE _is larger and would ordinarily be called more comfortable looking, but she is disturbed now and looks fearfully about as she enters. The women have come in slowly, and stand close together near the door_.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

(_rubbing his hands_) This feels good. Come up to the fire, ladies.

MRS PETERS

(_after taking a step forward_) I'm not--cold.

SHERIFF

(_unbuttoning his overcoat and stepping away from the stove as if to mark the beginning of official business_) Now, Mr Hale, before we move things about, you explain to Mr Henderson just what you saw when you came here yesterday morning.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

By the way, has anything been moved? Are things just as you left them yesterday?

SHERIFF

(_looking about_) It's just the same. When it dropped below zero last night I thought I'd better send Frank out this morning to make a fire for us--no use getting pneumonia with a big case on, but I told him not to touch anything except the stove--and you know Frank.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

Somebody should have been left here yesterday.

SHERIFF

Oh--yesterday. When I had to send Frank to Morris Center for that man who went crazy--I want you to know I had my hands full yesterday. I knew you could get back from Omaha by today and as long as I went over everything here myself--

COUNTY ATTORNEY

Well, Mr Hale, tell just what happened when you came here yesterday morning.

HALE

Harry and I had started to town with a load of potatoes. We came along the road from my place and as I got here I said, I'm going to see if I can't get John Wright to go in with me on a party telephone.' I spoke to Wright about it once before and he put me off, saying folks talked too much anyway, and all he asked was peace and quiet--I guess you know about how much he talked himself; but I thought maybe if I went to the house and talked about it before his wife, though I said to Harry that I didn't know as what his wife wanted made much difference to John--

COUNTY ATTORNEY

Let's talk about that later, Mr Hale. I do want to talk about that, but tell now just what happened when you got to the house.

HALE

I didn't hear or see anything; I knocked at the door, and still it was all quiet inside. I knew they must be up, it was past eight o'clock. So I knocked again, and I thought I heard somebody say, 'Come in.' I wasn't sure, I'm not sure yet, but I opened the door--this door (_indicating the door by which the two women are still standing_) and there in that rocker--(_pointing to it_) sat Mrs Wright.

(_They all look at the rocker_.)

COUNTY ATTORNEY

What--was she doing?

HALE

She was rockin' back and forth. She had her apron in her hand and was kind of--pleating it.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

And how did she--look?

HALE

Well, she looked queer.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

How do you mean--queer?

HALE

Well, as if she didn't know what she was going to do next. And kind of done up.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

How did she seem to feel about your coming?

HALE

Why, I don't think she minded--one way or other. She didn't pay much attention. I said, 'How do, Mrs Wright it's cold, ain't it?' And she said, 'Is it?'--and went on kind of pleating at her apron. Well, I was surprised; she didn't ask me to come up to the stove, or to set down, but just sat there, not even looking at me, so I said, 'I want to see John.' And then she--laughed. I guess you would call it a laugh. I thought of Harry and the team outside, so I said a little sharp: 'Can't I see John?' 'No', she says, kind o' dull like. 'Ain't he home?' says I. 'Yes', says she, 'he's home'. 'Then why can't I see him?' I asked her, out of patience. ''Cause he's dead', says she. _'Dead?'_ says I. She just nodded her head, not getting a bit excited, but rockin' back and forth. 'Why--where is he?' says I, not knowing what to say. She just pointed upstairs--like that (_himself pointing to the room above_) I got up, with the idea of going up there. I walked from there to here--then I says, 'Why, what did he die of?' 'He died of a rope round his neck', says she, and just went on pleatin' at her apron. Well, I went out and called Harry. I thought I might--need help. We went upstairs and there he was lyin'--

COUNTY ATTORNEY

I think I'd rather have you go into that upstairs, where you can point it all out. Just go on now with the rest of the story.

HALE

Well, my first thought was to get that rope off. It looked ... (_stops, his face twitches_) ... but Harry, he went up to him, and he said, 'No, he's dead all right, and we'd better not touch anything.' So we went back down stairs. She was still sitting that same way. 'Has anybody been notified?' I asked. 'No', says she unconcerned. 'Who did this, Mrs Wright?' said Harry. He said it business-like--and she stopped pleatin' of her apron. 'I don't know', she says. 'You don't _know?_' says Harry. 'No', says she. 'Weren't you sleepin' in the bed with him?' says Harry. 'Yes', says she, 'but I was on the inside'. 'Somebody slipped a rope round his neck and strangled him and you didn't wake up?' says Harry. 'I didn't wake up', she said after him. We must 'a looked as if we didn't see how that could be, for after a minute she said, 'I sleep sound'. Harry was going to ask her more questions but I said maybe we ought to let her tell her story first to the coroner, or the sheriff, so Harry went fast as he could to Rivers' place, where there's a telephone.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

And what did Mrs Wright do when she knew that you had gone for the coroner?

HALE

She moved from that chair to this one over here (_pointing to a small chair in the

corner_) and just sat there with her hands held together and looking down. I got a feeling that I ought to make some conversation, so I said I had come in to see if John wanted to put in a telephone, and at that she started to laugh, and then she stopped and looked at me--scared, (_the_ COUNTY ATTORNEY, _who has had his notebook out, makes a note_) I dunno, maybe it wasn't scared. I wouldn't like to say it was. Soon Harry got back, and then Dr Lloyd came, and you, Mr Peters, and so I guess that's all I know that you don't.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

(_looking around_) I guess we'll go upstairs first--and then out to the barn and around there, (_to the_ SHERIFF) You're convinced that there was nothing important here--nothing that would point to any motive.

SHERIFF

Nothing here but kitchen things.

(_The_ COUNTY ATTORNEY, _after again looking around the kitchen, opens the door of a cupboard closet. He gets up on a chair and looks on a shelf. Pulls his hand away, sticky_.)

COUNTY ATTORNEY

Here's a nice mess.

(_The women draw nearer_.)

MRS PETERS

(_to the other woman_) Oh, her fruit; it did freeze, (_to the_ LAWYER) She worried about that when it turned so cold. She said the fire'd go out and her jars would break.

SHERIFF

Well, can you beat the women! Held for murder and worryin' about her preserves.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

I guess before we're through she may have something more serious than preserves to worry about.

HALE

Well, women are used to worrying over trifles.

(_The two women move a little closer together_.)

COUNTY ATTORNEY

(_with the gallantry of a young politician_) And yet, for all their worries, what would we do without the ladies? (_the women do not unbend. He goes to the sink, takes a dipperful of water from the pail and pouring it into a basin, washes his hands. Starts to wipe them on the roller-towel, turns it for a cleaner place_) Dirty towels! (_kicks his foot against the pans under the sink_) Not much of a

housekeeper, would you say, ladies?

MRS HALE

(_stiffly_) There's a great deal of work to be done on a farm.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

To be sure. And yet (_with a little bow to her_) I know there are some Dickson county farmhouses which do not have such roller towels. (_He gives it a pull to expose its length again._)

MRS HALE

Those towels get dirty awful quick. Men's hands aren't always as clean as they might be.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

Ah, loyal to your sex, I see. But you and Mrs Wright were neighbors. I suppose you were friends, too.

MRS HALE

(_shaking her head_) I've not seen much of her of late years. I've not been in this house--it's more than a year.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

And why was that? You didn't like her?

MRS HALE

I liked her all well enough. Farmers' wives have their hands full, Mr Henderson. And then--

COUNTY ATTORNEY

Yes--?

MRS HALE

(_looking about_) It never seemed a very cheerful place.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

No--it's not cheerful. I shouldn't say she had the homemaking instinct.

MRS HALE

Well, I don't know as Wright had, either.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

You mean that they didn't get on very well?

MRS HALE

No, I don't mean anything. But I don't think a place'd be any cheerfuller for John Wright's being in it.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

I'd like to talk more of that a little later. I want to get the lay of things

upstairs now. (_He goes to the left, where three steps lead to a stair door_.)

SHERIFF

I suppose anything Mrs Peters does'll be all right. She was to take in some clothes for her, you know, and a few little things. We left in such a hurry yesterday.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

Yes, but I would like to see what you take, Mrs Peters, and keep an eye out for anything that might be of use to us.

MRS PETERS

Yes, Mr Henderson.

(_The women listen to the men's steps on the stairs, then look about the kitchen_.)

MRS HALE

I'd hate to have men coming into my kitchen, snooping around and criticising.

(_She arranges the pans under sink which the_ LAWYER _had shoved out of place_.)

MRS PETERS

Of course it's no more than their duty.

MRS HALE

Duty's all right, but I guess that deputy sheriff that came out to make the fire might have got a little of this on. (_gives the roller towel a pull_) Wish I'd thought of that sooner. Seems mean to talk about her for not having things slicked up when she had to come away in such a hurry.

MRS PETERS

(_who has gone to a small table in the left rear corner of the room, and lifted one end of a towel that covers a pan_) She had bread set. (_Stands still_.)

MRS HALE

(_eyes fixed on a loaf of bread beside the bread-box, which is on a low shelf at the other side of the room. Moves slowly toward it_) She was going to put this in there, (_picks up loaf, then abruptly drops it. In a manner of returning to familiar things_) It's a shame about her fruit. I wonder if it's all gone. (_gets up on the chair and looks_) I think there's some here that's all right, Mrs Peters. Yes--here; (_holding it toward the window_) this is cherries, too. (_looking again_) I declare I believe that's the only one. (_gets down, bottle in her hand. Goes to the sink and wipes it off on the outside_) She'll feel awful bad after all her hard work in the hot weather. I remember the afternoon I put up my cherries last summer.

(_She puts the bottle on the big kitchen table, center of the room. With a sigh, is about to sit down in the rocking-chair. Before she is seated realizes what chair it is; with a slow look at it, steps back. The chair which she has touched rocks back

and forth_.)

MRS PETERS

Well, I must get those things from the front room closet, (_she goes to the door at the right, but after looking into the other room, steps back_) You coming with me, Mrs Hale? You could help me carry them.

(_They go in the other room; reappear,_ MRS PETERS _carrying a dress and skirt,_ MRS HALE _following with a pair of shoes._)

MRS PETERS

My, it's cold in there.

(_She puts the clothes on the big table, and hurries to the stove._)

MRS HALE

(_examining the skirt_) Wright was close. I think maybe that's why she kept so much to herself. She didn't even belong to the Ladies Aid. I suppose she felt she couldn't do her part, and then you don't enjoy things when you feel shabby. She used to wear pretty clothes and be lively, when she was Minnie Foster, one of the town girls singing in the choir. But that--oh, that was thirty years ago. This all you was to take in?

MRS PETERS

She said she wanted an apron. Funny thing to want, for there isn't much to get you dirty in jail, goodness knows. But I suppose just to make her feel more natural. She said they was in the top drawer in this cupboard. Yes, here. And then her little shawl that always hung behind the door. (_opens stair door and looks_) Yes, here it is.

(_Quickly shuts door leading upstairs._)

MRS HALE

(_abruptly moving toward her_) Mrs Peters?

MRS PETERS

Yes, Mrs Hale?

MRS HALE

Do you think she did it?

MRS PETERS

(_in a frightened voice_) Oh, I don't know.

MRS HALE

Well, I don't think she did. Asking for an apron and her little shawl. Worrying about her fruit.

MRS PETERS

(starts to speak, glances up, where footsteps are heard in the room above. In a low voice_) Mr Peters says it looks bad for her. Mr Henderson is awful sarcastic in a speech and he'll make fun of her sayin' she didn't wake up.

MRS HALE

Well, I guess John Wright didn't wake when they was slipping that rope under his neck.

MRS PETERS

No, it's strange. It must have been done awful crafty and still. They say it was such a--funny way to kill a man, rigging it all up like that.

MRS HALE

That's just what Mr Hale said. There was a gun in the house. He says that's what he can't understand.

MRS PETERS

Mr Henderson said coming out that what was needed for the case was a motive; something to show anger, or--sudden feeling.

MRS HALE

(who is standing by the table_) Well, I don't see any signs of anger around here, (she puts her hand on the dish towel which lies on the table, stands looking down at table, one half of which is clean, the other half messy_) It's wiped to here, (makes a move as if to finish work, then turns and looks at loaf of bread outside the breadbox. Drops towel. In that voice of coming back to familiar things_) Wonder how they are finding things upstairs. I hope she had it a little more red-up up there. You know, it seems kind of sneaking. Locking her up in town and then coming out here and trying to get her own house to turn against her!

MRS PETERS

But Mrs Hale, the law is the law.

MRS HALE

I s'pose 'tis, (unbuttoning her coat_) Better loosen up your things, Mrs Peters. You won't feel them when you go out.

(MRS PETERS takes off her fur tippet, goes to hang it on hook at back of room, stands looking at the under part of the small corner table_.)

MRS PETERS

She was piecing a quilt. (She brings the large sewing basket and they look at the bright pieces_.)

MRS HALE

It's log cabin pattern. Pretty, isn't it? I wonder if she was goin' to quilt it or just knot it?

(_Footsteps have been heard coming down the stairs_. The SHERIFF enters followed by HALE and the COUNTY ATTORNEY.)

SHERIFF

They wonder if she was going to quilt it or just knot it! (_The men laugh, the women look abashed_.)

COUNTY ATTORNEY

(_rubbing his hands over the stove_) Frank's fire didn't do much up there, did it? Well, let's go out to the barn and get that cleared up. (_The men go outside_.)

MRS HALE

(_resentfully_) I don't know as there's anything so strange, our takin' up our time with little things while we're waiting for them to get the evidence. (_she sits down at the big table smoothing out a block with decision_) I don't see as it's anything to laugh about.

MRS PETERS

(_apologetically_) Of course they've got awful important things on their minds.

(_Pulls up a chair and joins MRS HALE at the table_.)

MRS HALE

(_examining another block_) Mrs Peters, look at this one. Here, this is the one she was working on, and look at the sewing! All the rest of it has been so nice and even. And look at this! It's all over the place! Why, it looks as if she didn't know what she was about!

(_After she has said this they look at each other, then start to glance back at the door. After an instant_ MRS HALE _has pulled at a knot and ripped the sewing_.)

MRS PETERS

Oh, what are you doing, Mrs Hale?

MRS HALE

(_mildly_) Just pulling out a stitch or two that's not sewed very good. (_threading a needle_) Bad sewing always made me fidgety.

MRS PETERS

(nervously) I don't think we ought to touch things.

MRS HALE

I'll just finish up this end. (_suddenly stopping and leaning forward_) Mrs Peters?

MRS PETERS

Yes, Mrs Hale?

MRS HALE

What do you suppose she was so nervous about?

MRS PETERS

Oh--I don't know. I don't know as she was nervous. I sometimes sew awful queer when I'm just tired. (MRS HALE _starts to say something, looks at_ MRS PETERS, _then goes on sewing_) Well I must get these things wrapped up. They may be through sooner than we think, (_putting apron and other things together_) I wonder where I can find a piece of paper, and string.

MRS HALE

In that cupboard, maybe.

MRS PETERS

(_looking in cupboard_) Why, here's a bird-cage, (_holds it up_) Did she have a bird, Mrs Hale?

MRS HALE

Why, I don't know whether she did or not--I've not been here for so long. There was a man around last year selling canaries cheap, but I don't know as she took one; maybe she did. She used to sing real pretty herself.

MRS PETERS

(_glancing around_) Seems funny to think of a bird here. But she must have had one, or why would she have a cage? I wonder what happened to it.

MRS HALE

I s'pose maybe the cat got it.

MRS PETERS

No, she didn't have a cat. She's got that feeling some people have about cats--being afraid of them. My cat got in her room and she was real upset and asked me to take it out.

MRS HALE

My sister Bessie was like that. Queer, ain't it?

MRS PETERS

(_examining the cage_) Why, look at this door. It's broke. One hinge is pulled apart.

MRS HALE

(_looking too_) Looks as if someone must have been rough with it.

MRS PETERS

Why, yes.

(_She brings the cage forward and puts it on the table_.)

MRS HALE

I wish if they're going to find any evidence they'd be about it. I don't like this place.

MRS PETERS

But I'm awful glad you came with me, Mrs Hale. It would be lonesome for me sitting here alone.

MRS HALE

It would, wouldn't it? (_dropping her sewing_) But I tell you what I do wish, Mrs Peters. I wish I had come over sometimes when _she_ was here. I--(_looking around the room_)--wish I had.

MRS PETERS

But of course you were awful busy, Mrs Hale--your house and your children.

MRS HALE

I could've come. I stayed away because it weren't cheerful--and that's why I ought to have come. I--I've never liked this place. Maybe because it's down in a hollow and you don't see the road. I dunno what it is, but it's a lonesome place and always was. I wish I had come over to see Minnie Foster sometimes. I can see now--(_shakes her head_)

MRS PETERS

Well, you mustn't reproach yourself, Mrs Hale. Somehow we just don't see how it is with other folks until--something comes up.

MRS HALE

Not having children makes less work--but it makes a quiet house, and Wright out to work all day, and no company when he did come in. Did you know John Wright, Mrs Peters?

MRS PETERS

Not to know him; I've seen him in town. They say he was a good man.

MRS HALE

Yes--good; he didn't drink, and kept his word as well as most, I guess, and paid his debts. But he was a hard man, Mrs Peters. Just to pass the time of day with him--(_shivers_) Like a raw wind that gets to the bone, (_pauses, her eye falling on the cage_) I should think she would 'a wanted a bird. But what do you suppose went with it?

MRS PETERS

I don't know, unless it got sick and died.

(_She reaches over and swings the broken door, swings it again, both women watch it_.)

MRS HALE

You weren't raised round here, were you? (_MRS PETERS shakes her head_) You didn't know--her?

MRS PETERS

Not till they brought her yesterday.

MRS HALE

She--come to think of it, she was kind of like a bird herself--real sweet and pretty, but kind of timid and--fluttery. How--she--did--change. (_silence; then as if struck by a happy thought and relieved to get back to everyday things_) Tell you what, Mrs Peters, why don't you take the quilt in with you? It might take up her mind.

MRS PETERS

Why, I think that's a real nice idea, Mrs Hale. There couldn't possibly be any objection to it, could there? Now, just what would I take? I wonder if her patches are in here--and her things.

(_They look in the sewing basket_.)

MRS HALE

Here's some red. I expect this has got sewing things in it. (_brings out a fancy box_) What a pretty box. Looks like something somebody would give you. Maybe her scissors are in here. (_Opens box. Suddenly puts her hand to her nose_) Why--(MRS PETERS _bends nearer, then turns her face away_) There's something wrapped up in this piece of silk.

MRS PETERS

Why, this isn't her scissors.

MRS HALE

(_lifting the silk_) Oh, Mrs Peters--it's--

(MRS PETERS _bends closer_.)

MRS PETERS

It's the bird.

MRS HALE

(_jumping up_) But, Mrs Peters--look at it! It's neck! Look at its neck!

It's all--other side _to_.

MRS PETERS

Somebody--wring--its--neck.

(_Their eyes meet. A look of growing comprehension, of horror. Steps are heard outside_. MRS HALE _slips box under quilt pieces, and sinks into her chair. Enter_ SHERIFF _and_ COUNTY ATTORNEY. MRS PETERS _rises_.)

COUNTY ATTORNEY

(_as one turning from serious things to little pleasantries_) Well ladies, have you

decided whether she was going to quilt it or knot it?

MRS PETERS

We think she was going to--knot it.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

Well, that's interesting, I'm sure. (_seeing the birdcage_) Has the bird flown?

MRS HALE

(_putting more quilt pieces over the box_) We think the--cat got it.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

(_preoccupied_) Is there a cat?

(MRS HALE _glances in a quick covert way at_ MRS PETERS.)

MRS PETERS

Well, not now. They're superstitious, you know. They leave.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

(_to_ SHERIFF PETERS, _continuing an interrupted conversation_) No sign at all of anyone having come from the outside. Their own rope. Now let's go up again and go over it piece by piece. (_they start upstairs_) It would have to have been someone who knew just the--

(MRS PETERS _sits down. The two women sit there not looking at one another, but as if peering into something and at the same time holding back. When they talk now it is in the manner of feeling their way over strange ground, as if afraid of what they are saying, but as if they can not help saying it_.)

MRS HALE

She liked the bird. She was going to bury it in that pretty box.

MRS PETERS

(_in a whisper_) When I was a girl--my kitten--there was a boy took a hatchet, and before my eyes--and before I could get there--(_covers her face an instant_) If they hadn't held me back I would have--(_catches herself, looks upstairs where steps are heard, falters weakly_)--hurt him.

MRS HALE

(_with a slow look around her_) I wonder how it would seem never to have had any children around, (_pause_) No, Wright wouldn't like the bird--a thing that sang. She used to sing. He killed that, too.

MRS PETERS

(_moving uneasily_) We don't know who killed the bird.

MRS HALE

I knew John Wright.

MRS PETERS

It was an awful thing was done in this house that night, Mrs Hale. Killing a man while he slept, slipping a rope around his neck that choked the life out of him.

MRS HALE

His neck. Choked the life out of him.

(Her hand goes out and rests on the bird-cage.)

MRS PETERS

(with rising voice) We don't know who killed him. We don't know.

MRS HALE

(her own feeling not interrupted) If there'd been years and years of nothing, then a bird to sing to you, it would be awful--still, after the bird was still.

MRS PETERS

(something within her speaking) I know what stillness is. When we homesteaded in Dakota, and my first baby died--after he was two years old, and me with no other then--

MRS HALE

(moving) How soon do you suppose they'll be through, looking for the evidence?

MRS PETERS

I know what stillness is. (pulling herself back) The law has got to punish crime, Mrs Hale.

MRS HALE

(not as if answering that) I wish you'd seen Minnie Foster when she wore a white dress with blue ribbons and stood up there in the choir and sang. (a look around the room) Oh, I wish I'd come over here once in a while! That was a crime! That was a crime! Who's going to punish that?

MRS PETERS

(looking upstairs) We mustn't--take on.

MRS HALE

I might have known she needed help! I know how things can be--for women. I tell you, it's queer, Mrs Peters. We live close together and we live far apart. We all go through the same things--it's all just a different kind of the same thing, (brushes her eyes, noticing the bottle of fruit, reaches out for it) If I was you, I wouldn't tell her her fruit was gone. Tell her it ain't. Tell her it's all right. Take this in to prove it to her. She--she may never know whether it was broke or not.

MRS PETERS

(takes the bottle, looks about for something to wrap it in; takes petticoat from

the clothes brought from the other room, very nervously begins winding this around the bottle. In a false voice_) My, it's a good thing the men couldn't hear us. Wouldn't they just laugh! Getting all stirred up over a little thing like a--dead canary. As if that could have anything to do with--with--wouldn't they _laugh_!

(_The men are heard coming down stairs_.)

MRS HALE

(_under her breath_) Maybe they would--maybe they wouldn't.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

No, Peters, it's all perfectly clear except a reason for doing it. But you know juries when it comes to women. If there was some definite thing. Something to show--something to make a story about--a thing that would connect up with this strange way of doing it--

(_The women's eyes meet for an instant. Enter HALE from outer door_.)

HALE

Well, I've got the team around. Pretty cold out there.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

I'm going to stay here a while by myself, (_to the_ SHERIFF) You can send Frank out for me, can't you? I want to go over everything. I'm not satisfied that we can't do better.

SHERIFF

Do you want to see what Mrs Peters is going to take in?

(_The_ LAWYER _goes to the table, picks up the apron, laughs_.)

COUNTY ATTORNEY

Oh, I guess they're not very dangerous things the ladies have picked out. (_Moves a few things about, disturbing the quilt pieces which cover the box. Steps back_) No, Mrs Peters doesn't need supervising. For that matter, a sheriff's wife is married to the law. Ever think of it that way, Mrs Peters?

MRS PETERS

Not--just that way.

SHERIFF

(_chuckling_) Married to the law. (_moves toward the other room_) I just want you to come in here a minute, George. We ought to take a look at these windows.

COUNTY ATTORNEY

(_scoffingly_) Oh, windows!

SHERIFF

We'll be right out, Mr Hale.

(HALE _goes outside. The_ SHERIFF _follows the_ COUNTY ATTORNEY _into the other room. Then_ MRS HALE _rises, hands tight together, looking intensely at_ MRS PETERS, _whose eyes make a slow turn, finally meeting_ MRS HALE_'s. A moment_ MRS HALE _holds her, then her own eyes point the way to where the box is concealed. Suddenly_ MRS PETERS _throws back quilt pieces and tries to put the box in the bag she is wearing. It is too big. She opens box, starts to take bird out, cannot touch it, goes to pieces, stands there helpless. Sound of a knob turning in the other room_. MRS HALE _snatches the box and puts it in the pocket of her big coat. Enter_ COUNTY ATTORNEY _and_ SHERIFF.)

COUNTY ATTORNEY

(_facetiously_) Well, Henry, at least we found out that she was not going to quilt it. She was going to--what is it you call it, ladies?

MRS HALE

(_her hand against her pocket_) We call it--knot it, Mr Henderson.

(CURTAIN)